

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Algebra	Linear equations in two variables	Hard

Question

$5x + 7y = 1$

$ax + by = 1$

In the given pair of equations, a and b are constants. The graph of this pair of equations in the xy -plane is a pair of perpendicular lines. Which of the following pairs of equations also represents a pair of perpendicular lines?

- Answer
- A. $10x + 7y = 1$
 $ax - 2by = 1$
- B. $10x + 7y = 1$
 $ax + 2by = 1$
- C. $10x + 7y = 1$
 $2ax + by = 1$
- D. $5x - 7y = 1$
 $ax + by = 1$

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is correct. Two lines are perpendicular if their slopes are negative reciprocals, meaning that the slope of the first line is equal to -1 divided by the slope of the second line. Each equation in the given pair of equations can be written in slope-intercept form, $y = mx + b$, where m is the slope of the graph of the equation in the xy -plane and $(0, b)$ is the y -intercept. For the first equation, $5x + 7y = 1$, subtracting $5x$ from both sides gives $7y = -5x + 1$, and dividing both sides of this equation by 7 gives $y = -\frac{5}{7}x + \frac{1}{7}$. Therefore, the slope of the graph of this equation is $-\frac{5}{7}$. For the second equation, $ax + by = 1$, subtracting ax from both sides gives $by = -ax + 1$, and dividing both sides of this equation by b gives $y = -\frac{a}{b}x + \frac{1}{b}$. Therefore, the slope of the graph of this equation is $-\frac{a}{b}$. Since the graph of the given pair of equations is a pair of perpendicular lines, the slope of the graph of the second equation, $-\frac{a}{b}$, must be the negative reciprocal of the slope of the graph of the first equation, $-\frac{5}{7}$. The negative reciprocal of $-\frac{5}{7}$ is $\frac{-1}{(-\frac{5}{7})}$, or $\frac{7}{5}$. Therefore, $-\frac{a}{b} = \frac{7}{5}$, or $\frac{a}{b} = -\frac{7}{5}$. Similarly, rewriting the equations in choice B in slope-intercept form yields $y = -\frac{10}{7}x + \frac{1}{7}$ and $y = -\frac{a}{2b}x + \frac{1}{2b}$. It follows that the slope of the graph of the first equation in choice B is $-\frac{10}{7}$ and the slope of the graph of the second equation in choice B is $-\frac{a}{2b}$. Since $\frac{a}{b} = -\frac{7}{5}$, $-\frac{a}{2b}$ is equal to $-\left(\frac{1}{2}\right)\left(-\frac{7}{5}\right)$, or $\frac{7}{10}$. Since $\frac{7}{10}$ is the negative reciprocal of $-\frac{10}{7}$, the pair of equations in choice B represents a pair of perpendicular lines.

Choice A is incorrect and may result from conceptual or calculation errors.

Choice C is incorrect and may result from conceptual or calculation errors.

Choice D is incorrect and may result from conceptual or calculation errors.